

Practice Paper 46 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Why the warning came from the gutters

1 mark for understanding that the sky had not yet shown obvious signs of the storm; **1 mark** for explaining that the **sound of water already rushing through the drains** told him the rain had begun nearby or was about to arrive heavily.

Sample answer: Uncle Heng could not yet see the storm in the sky, but the loud sound of water already pouring through the drains told him a heavy downpour was imminent — so the **evidence** of the storm reached him by **ear**, through the drains, before it reached him by **eye**.

Q2. [2] — Calm reaction to the storm

1 mark each for any two of:

- He “said nothing” while others around him were shouting.
- He “simply set down the bunch of greens in his hand.”
- He “wiped his palms on the front of his apron” — an everyday, unhurried action.
- He “began” without fuss or instruction from anyone.

Reject: general statements such as “he was calm” without textual evidence.

Q3. [2] — “Quickly but not in a hurry”

1 mark — He works with **efficiency** and **speed** because the situation requires it.

1 mark — He is not **panicked** or **flustered** because his **long experience** (thirty-one years) has taught him exactly what to do — the work has become **practised and habitual**.

Q4. [2] — “Coins thrown one by one onto the metal roof”

1 mark — The comparison captures the **sound** of the first heavy raindrops — sharp, metallic, separate.

1 mark — The image of **coins** is appropriate to a market setting (money, trade), and the words **one by one** emphasise that the rain is still **slow and individual**, just before it becomes a sheet.

Q5. [2] — Suddenness and heaviness of the rain

1 mark for a suitable choice; **1 mark** for explanation. Accept any one of:

- “all at once” — emphasises **suddenness**; the rain arrives without warning.
- “the sky opened” — a **metaphor** suggesting a vast, instantaneous release of water.
- “in a single sheet” — suggests a **solid wall** of water rather than separate drops.
- “so thick that the stall opposite vanished” — the rain is dense enough to **obscure vision**.

Q6. [2] — “Knew her hands the way he knew his own knife”

(a) [1]: The comparison suggests he has known her for a **very long time** — long enough for her hands to be as **familiar** to him as a tool he uses every day.

(b) [1]: It suggests she is **more than a customer**; she is a **part of his working life** and his daily routine — almost like a tool of the trade or a member of an extended community.

Q7. [2] — “Without a word being asked or given”

1 mark — Their relationship runs on an **unspoken understanding** / **unwritten code**: no permission needed to be sought, no thanks needed to be given.

1 mark — It reflects the **quiet trust** between long-standing neighbours / regulars — helping is **taken for granted** in the best sense of that phrase.

Q8. [1] — “Apologetic sound” of coins

1 mark: The word **apologetic** personifies the coins as if they were **sorry** for being wet, and conveys Uncle Heng’s **embarrassment** or **quiet regret** that his takings have been damaged — a moment of **gentle, almost humorous, dignity**. (Also accept: his attachment to his small earnings.)

Q9. [2] — “To make a fuss of it would have made it smaller than it was”

1 mark — If they had openly **thanked each other** or **discussed** the helping, the gesture would have become **ordinary** / **transactional**.

1 mark — By **not speaking** about it, they preserved the **deeper meaning** and **quiet importance** of what had happened — silence honoured it more than words could.

Q10. [2] — Why his gladness is “odd”

1 mark — Normally, a **physical ache** is something a person would **dislike** or **complain about**; it is unexpected to feel **glad** of pain.

1 mark — The ache is **evidence of honest work completed** — it tells him he has **protected his stock** and **done his job properly** despite the storm, so the discomfort becomes a **source of quiet pride** / **satisfaction**.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, quietly moved, grateful, tender, contemplative.** (Reject: **sad, lonely** — these miss the warmth.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Murky environmental record”

1 mark — Literal play: **murky** means cloudy / unclear, which is **ironic** given that bottled water is sold on the promise of **purity**.

1 mark — Figuratively, the record is **troubling** / **not clean** / **full of hidden harms** — the industry’s reputation does not match the clear image it projects.

Q13. [2] — Purpose of listing the four stages

1 mark — The list shows the reader the **whole chain** of activities behind one bottle, which most consumers never see.

1 mark — It emphasises that the **environmental cost** is not in the product itself but is **accumulated** at every stage — extraction, bottling, freight, refrigeration — making the total impact much greater than the bottle suggests.

Q14. [2] — Reasons for the large carbon footprint

1 mark each for any two of:

- The bottle is made from **oil-derived plastic (PET)**; the cap and label require **additional plastics**.
- The bottle is **shipped**, sometimes **across continents**, in **refrigerated lorries** that **run on diesel**.
- The water must be **chilled** throughout the journey and at the shelf.
- Compared with tap water, the bottled product emits hundreds of times more CO₂-equivalent per litre.

Q15. [2] — “Insidious”

1 mark: Insidious suggests something **gradual** / **hidden** / **operating quietly** — its harm is not immediately obvious.

1 mark: Unlike carbon emissions, which can be measured at the factory gate, plastic contamination **enters the body unnoticed** and may cause damage **over time**, which makes it especially dangerous.

Q16. [2] — Comparison “roughly a hundred times higher”

1 mark — It conveys the **shocking scale** of the new finding and the **inadequacy** of earlier estimates.

1 mark — It also emphasises that the **true scale of plastic contamination** has only recently come into view, and may be far greater than even cautious consumers have assumed.

Q17. [2] — “Stranger still”

1 mark — In countries such as Singapore, the UK, Germany and Japan, **tap water is already safe** and tested to the same or stricter standards as bottled water.

1 mark — It is therefore **irrational** / **paradoxical** that consumers in these places continue to buy

bottled water, since there is no **measurable** health benefit — only a **perceived** one created by marketing.

Q18. [2] — Belief as the product of marketing (own words)

1 mark — Consumers' confidence in bottled water comes from **decades of clever advertising** — images of mountains, snow and springs — rather than from any real difference.

1 mark — **At the chemical / molecular level**, tap and bottled water are **practically the same**; the supposed superiority of bottled water exists only in the **consumer's mind**, not in the **water itself**.

Reject answers that lift “carefully marketed” or “molecular level” without rewording.

Q19. [2] — European measures

1 mark each for any two of:

- Paris has installed **more than 1,200 free sparkling-water fountains** across the city.
- Berlin has **banned single-use plastic bottles from municipal events**.
- The EU's 2020 Drinking Water Directive obliges member states to **actively promote tap water in public buildings**.

Q20. [2] — The concession in Paragraph 6

1 mark — The writer **concedes** that bottled water has **legitimate uses** — in **emergencies** (floods, earthquakes, contamination scares) and in **places without safe tap supplies**.

1 mark — He includes this concession to appear **fair and balanced**, and to **sharpen** his real argument: that in **wealthy nations with safe supplies**, bottled water has come to occupy a **far larger place than is justified**.

Q21. [2] — Effect of the two short sentences

1 mark — The **short, parallel sentences** create a deliberate, almost stark rhythm; they slow the reader and signal **honesty** — the writer is not overselling his solutions.

1 mark — They also **pre-empt the reader's scepticism** (that individual habits are too small to matter) and prepare for the writer's larger point — that **small acts**, multiplied across a population, **are** the change.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Environmental and health costs (Paragraphs 2–5):

1. Producing, transporting and **chilling** each litre of bottled water emits **0.2–0.3 kg of CO₂-equivalent** — hundreds of times more than tap water.
2. The bottle, cap and label all require **fossil-fuel-derived plastics** and are shipped, often across continents, in **diesel-powered refrigerated lorries**.
3. A litre of bottled water contains around **240,000 plastic fragments**, mostly **nanoplastics**.

4. These particles can **enter the bloodstream** and have been found in **human placentas, lungs and brains**, with early links to **inflammation and endocrine disruption**.
5. Much of this consumption occurs in countries where **tap water is already safe**, so the harm is being inflicted **needlessly**.

What can be done (Paragraphs 5 and 7):

6. Cities can install **public drinking fountains** (Paris) and **ban single-use bottles at official events** (Berlin); the EU **promotes tap water in public buildings**.
7. Individuals can **carry and refill a reusable bottle**, sparing the planet hundreds of bottles a year.
8. **Employers** can stop providing single-use bottles, and **schools** can again teach children to **drink from the tap**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Bottled water harms the planet and the body because every litre emits hundreds of times more carbon than tap water, requires oil-based plastics and refrigerated transport, and carries hundreds of thousands of tiny plastic fragments that enter human organs. Worse, much of it is drunk where the tap is already safe. To reduce this, cities can build public fountains and ban single-use bottles, while individuals can refill reusable bottles and schools can teach tap-drinking again.

Length count: 78 words from “Bottled” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —